

The fruit juice is cleansing and tonic, and has often been used as a gargle and mouthwash. The root bark may be used for toothache, and it is considered laxative. An extract of the leaves has been given by injection for elephantiasis. The twigs are used to combat excess fluid retention and joint pain. The fruit is taken to prevent premature graying of the hair, and to treat dizziness, ringing in the ears, blurred vision, and insomnia.

Related Species The black mulberry (*M. nigra*), native to Iran, is cultivated for its sweet, deep red fruit.

Murraya koenigii (Rutaceae) Curry Tree

Description Aromatic deciduous shrub or tree growing to 20 ft (6 m). Has strongly scented leaves, clusters of small, fragrant white flowers, and pink to black berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Curry tree is native to subtropical forests in much of southern Asia. It is widely cultivated in India for its leaves.

Parts Used Leaves, berries.

Constituents Curry tree contains over 20 alkaloids, a glycoside (koenigin), volatile oil, and tannins.

History & Folklore Curry tree, also known as curry patta, is a common flavoring in Indian food.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Curry tree leaves increase digestive secretions and relieve nausea, indigestion, and vomiting. They are also used to treat diarrhea and dysentery. Curry tree aids healing, for example in gastric ulcers, and the leaves are applied as a poultice on wounds and burns. It helps to stabilize blood-sugar levels and is useful for type 2 diabetes.

Related Species The very bitter leaves of cosmetic bark (*M. paniculata*) are taken to treat stomach ache, dysentery, toothache, and bruises.

Musa spp. (Musaceae) Banana, Plantain

Description Evergreen, palm-like perennials growing to 30 ft (9 m). Have large, shiny green leaves, hanging flowering stems, and bunches of elongated green fruit that turn yellow on ripening.

Habitat & Cultivation *Musa* species are native to India and Southeast Asia, and are extensively cultivated in tropical and subtropical regions. The fruit is generally picked when



Bananas are picked before they fully ripen. They are a useful remedy for diarrhea.

immature and then allowed to ripen. The leaves are gathered as required.

Parts Used Fruit, leaves, root.

Constituents The fruit contains flavonoids and is rich in vitamins B, C, and E, potassium, serotonin, and noradrenaline.

History & Folklore The delicious and highly nutritious banana fruit is the yield of careful horticulture, which had its origins with wild plants in prehistoric times.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Ripe banana fruit is gently laxative, while the unripe fruit is astringent and used to treat diarrhea. The fruit stimulates hemoglobin production and can therefore prove useful in preventing or treating anemia. Banana makes a simple addition to diets aimed at lowering high blood pressure. Given the fruit's serotonin content, some practitioners recommend taking three bananas a day to help treat migraines and depression. A syrup made from plantain is taken for coughs and chest conditions such as bronchitis.

Myrica cerifera (Myricaceae) Bayberry

Description Evergreen shrub or small tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has narrow leaves, small yellow flowers in catkins, and waxy gray berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Bayberry is found in coastal regions of the eastern and southern U.S., as far west as Texas. The root bark is collected in autumn or spring.

Part Used Root bark.

Constituents Bayberry contains triterpenes (including taraxerol, taraxerone, and myricadiol), flavonoids, tannins, phenols, resins, and gums. Myricadiol has a mild effect on potassium and sodium levels.

History & Folklore Settlers in North America extolled the medicinal benefits of bayberry. A 1737 account stated that the plants "expel wind and ease all manner of pains proceeding from cold, therefore are good in colic, palsies, convulsions, epilepsies, and many other disorders." The root bark was listed in the *U.S. National Formulary* from 1916 to 1936.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Bayberry is used to increase circulation, stimulate perspiration, and keep bacterial infections in check. Colds, flu, coughs, and sore throats benefit from treatment with this herb. It helps to strengthen resistance to infection and to tighten and dry mucous membranes. An infusion is helpful for spongy gums, and a gargle is used for sore throats. Bayberry's astringency is beneficial for irritable bowel syndrome and mucous colitis. An infusion can help treat excess vaginal discharge. A paste of the powdered root bark may be used externally on ulcers and sores.

Caution Do not take in pregnancy.

Myrica gale (Myricaceae) Sweet Gale, Bog Myrtle

Description Low-growing, fragrant shrub, growing to 6½ ft (2 m), with lance-shaped leaves. Male plants produce resinous catkins in spring.

Habitat & Cultivation Sweet gale thrives in wet and damp heaths and moorlands across northerly regions of the northern hemisphere. The leaves are collected in summer; the catkins in spring.

Parts Used Leaves, branches, catkins.

Constituents Sweet gale contains an essential oil (chiefly alpha-pinene and delta-cadinene), flavonoids, and resin.

History & Folklore In Scotland, where the plant grows freely, Highlanders slept on fleaproof beds of sweet gale and placed it among linen to repel moths. Enterprising anglers are also reported to have worn sprigs of sweet gale to keep away midges. In Scotland and Sweden, a strong decoction was used to kill insects and intestinal worms.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sweet gale is mostly used as an insect repellent and insecticide and offers a safe and ecologically sound way to protect against insect bites. Over-the-counter preparations are available, though a decoction of the plant bathed on exposed areas will also prove effective.

Research Since the 1990s, the essential oil of sweet gale has become recognized as an effective insect repellent (especially of midges), and is now available in blended formulations. In one trial in Scotland, volunteers exposed their arms to midges, with one arm covered in a gel containing essential oil of sweet gale. After 10 minutes, the protected arms averaged 1.6 bites, the unprotected arms 9.4.